



ROSIE LEE, on her 19-acre farm in Merced, is leaving half the land dry and unplanted because of regulations. TOMAS OVALLE For The Times

ICE detainee water appears tainted

Video of worm-like creatures highlights persistent complaints at Adelanto lockup.

By RUBEN VIVES

Carlos Ricardo Parias had long complained to his family about the quality of drinking water at the Adelanto ICE Processing Center.

In a video call from the Southern California facility where he is detained, he finally showed them proof — a plastic bottle filled with drinking water and what appeared to be worm-like creatures.

Carlos Jurado, Parias' immigration attorney, shared a copy of the video with The Times. In a phone interview, he said no one should drink something like it.

"The saddest thing is that they hunt us like animals on the streets and they don't even treat us like animals in jails because no one would give that kind of water to their dog or cat," Jurado said.

A Department of Homeland Security spokesperson, however, denied any claim of poor conditions at the facility, saying it gets its water from the city of Adelanto.

"It is the same water used by residents and businesses in the area," the spokesperson wrote in an email to The Times. "Our staff members at the facility also consume the water alongside illegal aliens. Employees and illegal aliens have access to this water supply 24/7 through water fountains [See Adelanto, A8]

SMALL FARMERS LEFT OUT TO DRY

State law that protects groundwater is financially straining family operations that may end up losing land to industrial growers

By Ian James | REPORTING FROM MERCED, CALIF.

Last year, Rosie Lee's 19-acre farm was filled with crops including corn, beans, squash, tomatoes, melons, onions and bok choy — so much that she and her husband had plenty to sell at a farmers market.

Now, she is leaving half her land dry and unplanted. She's uncertain how much water she can afford to pump from her well this year because the local groundwater agency has imposed pumping restrictions and fees, which could end up costing thousands of dollars.

"It's preventing me from growing what I used to grow," Lee said as she stood beside a bare-dirt field. "We're afraid that we do not make enough to pay for the water."

While California's landmark groundwater conservation law was designed to rein in massive agricultural overpumping, Lee and other small-scale growers say its implementation is doing the opposite — penalizing small farms while favoring industrial agribusinesses.

According to a new report, rigid fee structures and complex regulations threaten to harm California's smallest growers, driving land consolidation in favor of deep-pocketed corporate orchards.

The report by the University of California Small Farms Network and the non-profit group Community Alliance with Family Farmers warns that without immediate action by state and local agencies, many family farms could be forced out of business.

In many areas of the San Joaquin Valley, water agencies have adopted flat fees, so the largest landowners are paying the same per-volume rate as the smallest ones.

However, small growers often have shallower wells that are more vulnerable to going dry when water levels drop. Pumping restrictions can also be more difficult for a grower with 20 acres than for a big business operating on thousands of acres.

[See Groundwater, A9]

Infantino's spectacular misfire

FIFA chief's bid to sell World Cup stake stirs outrage

By KEVIN BAXTER

Heading into the final weekend of this summer's World Cup, the Guardian reported that support for FIFA president Gianni Infantino had climbed to record levels. More than 200 of FIFA's 211 member associations formally endorsed Infantino's bid for a fourth term as head of world soccer's governing body, the paper reported, making next March's vote more of a coronation than an election.

Two weeks later, that support disappeared. Not only is Infantino's reelection campaign in tatters, but there's a chance he won't

survive until the spring, with British Prime Minister Andy Burnham and Javier Tebas, president of Spain's soccer association, calling for his resignation and close confidants such as Carlos Cordeiro, the former president of U.S. Soccer, and Kevin Lamour, FIFA's chief operating officer, publicly breaking with their boss.

That was Friday. On Saturday, the pressure on Infantino increased with the Union of European Football Assns. (UEFA), the governing body for soccer in Europe and the most influential of FIFA's six continental confederations, and CONCACAF, the largest of two confederations overseeing the

sport in the Americas, both issuing statements saying they have lost confidence with FIFA leadership, leaving Infantino's future very much in doubt.

"No option should be off the table" to address that, UEFA said, while CONCACAF declared that "a comprehensive reckoning with this presidency is imperative."

At the center of that dramatic reversal in Infantino's future was a closely guarded scheme the FIFA president had to raise \$4.2 billion by selling a 20% stake in the World Cup to private investors, who would be given influence in planning and

[See Infantino, A4]

Bass' summer of discontent poses obstacle to reelection

Warehouse fire, rise in homelessness and staff turnover create new campaign challenges.

By NOAH GOLDBERG

Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass was riding relatively high two months ago, weathering pitched challenges from Spencer Pratt on the right and Nithya Raman on the left to emerge as the top vote-getter in the city's June 2 mayoral primary.

"Tomorrow begins the second half of this journey," an ebullient Bass told supporters at the Line Hotel in Koreatown on election night.

There's been a lot less to cheer about lately.

Bass' summer has been beset by a string of negative news. Staff members on both her campaign and administration teams have left. She was away from the city — just as she was at the

Mayor tops rival in fundraising

Bass received \$510,000 in contributions in June while Raman raised \$170,000. CALIFORNIA, B1

start of the devastating 2025 wildfires — when a blaze ignited at the Lineage cold-storage food warehouse in Boyle Heights, inundating the heavily Latino surrounding neighborhoods with noxious fumes.

And that was all before the release of a new report showing that homelessness in the city rose for the first time in three years, undercutting a pillar of Bass' fall runoff campaign against Raman.

"In terms of policy, politics and operations, I don't know if there has been a single piece of good news that has come out of her camp since the primary," said Dan Schnur, a professor of political communications at USC, [See Bass, A10]

Chinese media mogul faces probe

FBI targets a West Covina exec who rode an immigration wave to create an empire.

By RICHARD WINTON AND HANNAH FRY

James Su is far from a household name in Southern California, but in parts of the San Gabriel Valley, he was a true media mogul.

He founded EDI Media in the early 1990s, riding a wave of Asian immigration to create one of the largest Chinese media platforms in the U.S. with radio programs, a magazine and a digital news site. The company says the empire broadcasts more than 2,000 hours of programming annually, reaching more than 35 million people worldwide.

Su's bio on the EDI Media website boasts that in 2012 then-state Assemblyman Curt Hagman put forth a resolution giving Su his own day in California. However, The Times was not able to confirm legislation by any author relating to the declaration of a James Su Day during Hagman's terms in the Assembly.

Now, both Hagman and Su have been served search warrants as part of a widening FBI investigation into foreign influence in local politics.

Agents last week raided Hagman and Su's offices and homes, along with other locations in the Inland Empire and Beverly Hills. While authorities have declined to comment on the case, it comes amid a federal probe into the ways the Chinese government has made in-

[See Su, A8]

'Super' El Niño could gut crab and salmon catch

By SUSANNE RUST

As the chances of a "super" El Niño continue to rise — now 81%, according to federal scientists — researchers are looking back to 2015 and 2016, when a Pacific heat wave combined with a strong El Niño threw some of the West Coast's most important commercial fishing fleets into turmoil.

They say we could be looking at a repeat. Or worse.

"I think we're likely to break global temperature records with this next El Niño," said Malin Pinsky,



BRIAN VAN DER BRUG Los Angeles Times

MARINE SPECIES are at risk of a possible "super" El Niño that could wreak havoc for fishing fleets.

professor of ecology and evolutionary biology at UC Santa Cruz. "So it's very concerning and it is likely to have very big impacts on marine fisheries."

As ocean waters warm, plants and animals respond. Some die. Some don't reproduce. Some move north. Others go to deeper water. Then there are those that get sick or become susceptible to pathogens fueled by the increasing temperatures.

Marine species are shifting their ranges five to 10 times faster than land species in response to global [See Fishing, A10]



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

AWED BY HIS 'AURA'

Myles Garrett, the Rams' new defensive star, impresses his teammates with his energy as training camp gets underway. SPORTS, D1

SpaceX rocket to crash into moon

Discarded spacecraft is on a collision course after launching a pair of lunar landers last year. PERSPECTIVES, A2

Weather

Mostly sunny; warm. L.A. Basin: 91/69. B8

Business A12 Opinion Voices A16

L.A.'s ultimate birthday cake

The Times Food team took readers' notes and created one worth celebrating. WEEKEND, L6

For the latest news, go to latimes.com.



7 85944 10300 9